paper was published—and hardly anyone paid any attention. Black-hole radiation just seemed horribly implausible.

A year later, at the Les. Houches summer school, we “experts” were still ignoring Zel’dovich’s idea. I don’t recall it being mentioned even onece.[10]

In September 1973, I was back in Moscow once again, this time accompanying Stephen Hawking and his wife Jane. This was Stephen’s first trip to Moscow since his student days. He, Jane, and Zel’dovich (our Soviet host), uneasy about how to cope in Moscow with Stephen’s special needs, thought it best that I, being familiar with Moscow and a close friend of Stephen’s and Jane’s, act as their companion, translator for physics conversations, and guide.

We stayed at the Hotel Rossiya, just off Red Square near the Kremlin Although we ventured out nearly every day to give lectures at one institute or another, or to visit a museum or the opera or ballet, our interactions with Soviet physicists occurred for the most part in the Hawkings’ two-room hotel suite, with its view of St. Basil’s Cathedral. One after another, the Soviet Union’s leading theoretical physicists came to the hotel to pay homage to Hawking and to converse.

Among the physicists who made repeated trips to Hawking’s hotel room were Zel’dovich and his graduate student Alexi Starobinsky. Hawking found Zel’dovich and Starobinsky as fascinating as they did him. On one visit, Starobinsky described Zel’dovich’s conjecture that a spinning black hole should radiate, described a partial marriage of quantum mechanics with general relativity that he and Zel’dovich had developed (based on earlier, pioneering work by Bryce DeWitt, Leonard Parker, and others), and then described a proof, using this partial marriage, that a spinning hole does, indeed, radiate. Zel’dovich was well on his way toward winning his bet with me.